

- Part 1
 - Philosophy of Sports
 - Philosophy and Political
 - Discussion Questions
 - Individual
 - Political and Social
 - Epistemology and Embodiment
 - Discussion Questions
 - Aesthetics and Athletics
 - Discussion Questions
- Part 2
 - Play, Game, and Sport
 - Play a Game
 - The World Cup and Political
 - Discussion Questions
 - The World Cup and Epistemology
 - Discussion Questions
 - The World Cup, Aesthetics, and Ethics
 - Discussion Questions
 - Conclusion
 - Discussion Questions

Part 1

hold this question, we will return to it at the end: *Why does sport matter? Not why it is popular, not why it is profitable but why should we care about sports.

What do you think philosophy of sport is?

Philosophy of Sports

The philosophy of sport asks fundamental questions about competition, rules, fairness, embodiment, excellence, and why humans are so deeply involved in sport and games.

Despite its importance it has largely sat dormant since its inception in the ancient world.

Its intellectual revival came only in the mid - 20th century, when philosophers such as **Paul Weiss** (Sport: A Philosophic Inquiry, 1969) and **Howard Slusher** (Man, Sport, and Existence, 1967) argued that sport deserved the same conceptual seriousness as other human practices. Their work helped establish the modern discipline and opened the door for later scholars to develop a rich philosophical tradition.

In doing so, they were recovering something the Greeks already knew.

Philosophy and Political

In 776 BCE, the founding of the Olympic Games at Olympia marked the emergence of new Greek ideas about competition and human excellence. The Panhellenic festival drew participants from across the Greek world, and although limited to free Greek males, it stood out for transcending distinctions of birth and wealth. All competitors submitted to the same authoritative rules; cheaters were fined, and their penalties funded statues of Zeus that reminded future athletes of the moral stakes of the Games.

The Olympics were never mere entertainment. They were religious festivals, political theaters, and arenas where philosophical questions were enacted in body and motion.

Heather Reid's work urges us to recover that seriousness — to ask what sport **means**, not merely how it functions. For the Greeks, competition (agōn) was not a diversion from the good life but one of its highest expressions. Victory conferred timē (honor) and revealed aretē (excellence), the same quality pursued by philosophers and demanded of democratic citizens.

Discussion Questions

Individual

1. Do you think sport teaches virtue because of its structure (rules, discipline) or because of its culture (coaches, fans, values)? Is it different in amateur setting s professional? Where do the values come from?

- Is excellence the same thing as virtue, or can you have one without the other? Where do you think we could do better?
 - Do spectators and society influence how we do sport
2. In what ways is athleticism similar to Philosophy?
- What does 'practice' look like in each? Do both require self - knowledge? Is there a shared idea of 'excellence' in thinking and moving?

Political and Social

1. In your opinion how can a society benefit from **competition** and from **cooperation** as demonstrated in sports? Do you think there are dangers of excluding one aspect?
- What about free speech and competition of ideas? What about competition in economics driving innovation? What about competition motivates to strive for higher ideals?
 - Cooperation as means to me more effective than alone? What about cooperation implies harmony and satisfaction in life?
 - Healthy competition vs unhealthy competition?
2. What does athletic competition reveal about human nature that other activities might not?
- Is striving itself a basic human impulse? What about our ability to form identities? Construct agreed upon behaviors? Meaning Making?

Epistemology and Embodiment

When we think about epistemology, we often default to **propositional knowledge** within a **traditional analytic frame** — think of Plato. Logic and science are built on propositions, and their success seems to vindicate the approach. On this view, knowledge is justified true belief.

Gilbert Ryle famously distinguished **knowing that** from **knowing how**. To know that water boils at 100°C is propositional; it can be stated, tested, transmitted. But to know how to ride a bicycle is something else entirely: no list of propositions will teach you

balance. Sport is saturated with this second kind of knowledge — refined, embodied, and often inaccessible to language.

Michael Polanyi called this **tacit knowledge**: “we know more than we can tell.” Perhaps the mind’s most important operations happen below the level of explicit reasoning. This challenges the supremacy of propositional knowledge and suggests a new frontier of knowledge beyond the border of words.

Heather Reid argues that athletics gives us a lived answer to the **mind–body problem**: sport shows that thinking and moving are not separate realms but two aspects of a single, integrated human agency. Athletic excellence depends on embodied intelligence, tacit knowledge, emotional attunement, and physical discipline working together in ways that dualistic metaphysics cannot explain. Drawing on ancient Greek ideals of aretē, she treats sport as a practice that cultivates unified virtue—where moral, mental, and physical development are inseparable. For Reid, the athlete is not a mind using a body but a whole person expressing meaning, identity, and understanding through action.

Discussion Questions

1. If elite athletic knowledge is genuinely **tacit** — pre-reflective, embodied, resistant to articulation — then how is it ever taught? What does it mean to transmit something that cannot be fully said?
 - Does failure play a role in learning tacit skills? Is imitation a form of knowledge transmission?
2. Can you genuinely understand a practice (music, sport, teaching, politics) without being able to do it?
 - What’s happening when coaches that cannot play still get good results?
 - If we also play a sport how does that influence our appreciation of it?
3. Are there forms of **knowing - how** that can never be captured in language and if so, what does that say about the limits of philosophy?
 - Would anyone say that philosophy itself depends on Tacit knowing? Would the gym count as embodied epistemology?

4. Do you think expertise works the same everywhere, or does it only make sense inside a specific context or community?
 - Do communities create their own standards of excellence? What happens when expertise travels across cultures?
5. Can virtues like courage, discipline, or humility be meaningfully separated into ‘mental’ and ‘physical’ components, or are they inherently embodied?

Aesthetics and Athletics

Heather Reid argues that the aesthetics of sport arise from the way athletic action makes human excellence visible. In soccer, beauty emerges not from decoration or style for its own sake but from the harmonious coordination of skilled players pursuing a shared goal under conditions of risk and uncertainty. A fluid passing sequence, a perfectly timed tackle, or a moment of improvisational brilliance is aesthetically powerful because it expresses virtues like intelligence, courage, discipline, and cooperation. For Reid, soccer’s beauty is inseparable from its moral dimension: the game dramatizes human striving, reveals character, and transforms embodied skill into a form of meaningful, perceptible excellence.

In **David Best’s** influential distinction between **purposive sports** and **aesthetic sports**. In purposive sports—football, boxing, sprinting—the aesthetic dimension is incidental; success is defined by achieving an external goal, and beauty is at most a fortunate byproduct. In aesthetic sports—gymnastics, diving, figure skating—the aesthetic is the criterion of success. The “how” cannot be separated from the “what.”

Yet Best’s distinction quickly becomes unstable. Purposive sports routinely generate aesthetic judgments: we praise a “beautiful” pass, an “elegant” takedown, a striker who moves “like poetry in motion.” Conversely, aesthetic sports are never free of purposive pressures; the figure skater is not simply creating an expressive performance but competing for points under a codified scoring system. The competitive frame reintroduces instrumental goals that sit uneasily with purely aesthetic values.

Discussion Questions

1. Why do you think synchronized swimming is considered a sport while ballet is art?

- Does the goals of each impact how we consider them? Do you think its possible competition could intensify the aesthetic experience?
 - Means and ends are exactly the same for Art but sports the end is to win which is not the same as the means
2. Can a team play “beautifully” and still lose—and if so, what does that say about the purpose of sport?
- What is the telos of sport?
 - Does sport consist of competing values?
 - Is excellence tied to winning?
3. Is there something morally admirable about beautiful play, or is beauty in sport completely separate from virtue?
- Connects aesthetics to ethics in a way Reid emphasizes.
 - Development of Virtue (Technical Virtue vs moral Virtue)
4. Why do we admire creativity and risk-taking in soccer even when it fails—what does that reveal about human nature?
- Explores uncertainty, striving, and the aesthetic value of risk.

Part 2

Play, Game, and Sport

Essence is play

Johan Huizinga, in *Homo Ludens*, thought that play is not just a feature of games or sports, it is a fundamental category of human (and animal) life — free, voluntary, absorbing, set apart from "ordinary" life by its own rules and space. Culture itself, he argued, *arises in and as* play.

Essence is self imposed difficulty

Bernard Suits, in *The Grasshopper: Games, Life and Utopia*, proposed that playing a game means "the voluntary attempt to overcome unnecessary obstacles." A golfer could simply carry the ball to the hole — the rules forbid it. The whole point is the self-imposed constraint. On this view, the essence of sport is *chosen difficulty*.

Heather Reid argues that play is the most basic human activity: free, spontaneous, and done for its own sake. Games emerge when play becomes structured by rules, goals, and shared meanings that create an artificial world in which success and failure matter. Sport is a further refinement — a type of game defined by physical skill, competition, and social institutions that elevate it into a cultural practice. For Reid, sport is not just organized play but a moral arena where societies negotiate values like fairness, excellence, honor, and human flourishing.

Play a Game

Transition: Before we apply these frameworks to the World Cup, let's test them on some harder cases. The following activity asks you to place real activities within the models — where things resist easy placement is where the philosophy begins.

The World Cup and Political

The FIFA World Cup is, by most measures, the largest shared human event that regularly occurs on earth. The 2022 final between Argentina and France was watched by an estimated 1.5 billion people simultaneously. It is simultaneously: a sporting contest, an aesthetic spectacle, a site of national identity and political symbolism, a commercial enterprise of staggering scale.

Discussion Questions

1. The World Cup is contested between *nations*, not clubs or individuals. National teams carry an identity that goes far beyond sport — they represent histories, colonial legacies, political conflicts, and cultural pride.

Does this mean the World Cup is *more than* a sport — a ritual, a political event, a form of collective identity performance? And if so, does that change its relationship to play? Is there anything still *playful* about the World Cup?

- Representations of identity
- Rituals involve collective emotion, symbolic action, and periodic repetition
- Synchronized behavior (chants, colors, flags)
- Does Play requires freedom, spontaneity, and non - seriousness

- If the World Cup is ritual/politics/identity, then sport is never “just a game.”
- Does national identity enrich the meaning of the World Cup or corrupt it?
- Would the World Cup be better if it were less political or is the politics part of its power?
- Is the pressure of representing a nation elevating (virtue, courage) or distorting (fear, gamesmanship)?

The World Cup and Epistemology

Discussion Questions

1. The World Cup brings together players from dozens of different football cultures — each with its own bodily habits, tactical languages, and ways of understanding the game. When a South American player joins a European pressing system, or when a coach attempts to transmit a philosophy across a language barrier in a tournament setting, what is actually being transmitted?

Is there a football *language* that transcends cultural difference — or are there genuinely incommensurable footballing knowledges?

- Cultures produce different **motor vocabularies**: how to receive, how to press, how to combine, how to improvise.
- Some knowledge is **explicit** (pressing triggers, tactical shapes)
- Some is **implicit** (how to feel pressure, how to read chaos, how to improvise)
- Is it separate Language or different Dialects? (universalism vs pluralism)
- Perception vs Tactic
- Does globalization enrich football by blending knowledges — or flatten it by erasing cultural difference?

2. The best players at a World Cup often describe their peak performances as effortless, automatic, beyond thought. Messi after scoring a great goal: "I don't think — I just play." But those players also prepare with obsessive tactical analysis, video study, and physical monitoring.

How do we reconcile the prepared and the spontaneous, the analytical and the intuitive, in understanding what a great World Cup performance *is*?

Analytical

- Tactical study builds mental models of space, movement, and opponent tendencies
- Anticipatory knowledge — players know what is likely before it happens
- Outside of Match

Intuitive

- Embodied — a form of knowing that bypasses conscious deliberation
- Flow states reduce self-consciousness, enabling pure action
- During Match

Is Messi's "I don't think" a description of reality — or a myth we tell about genius?

Is intuition superior to analysis — the "true" form of footballing genius?

Or is intuition simply compressed analysis, running too fast to notice?

Is great performance the triumph of instinct over thought — or the triumph of thought so deeply internalized that it becomes instinct?

The World Cup, Aesthetics, and Ethics

Discussion Questions

1. Soccer has been called the "beautiful game", What makes a moment in soccer "beautiful"?
 - The skill itself, the teamwork behind it, or the meaning of the moment?
 - Control, risk, harmony, power, creativity?
 - Beauty can be formal (shape, timing, balance), expressive (creativity, daring), or narrative (stakes, meaning)
 - A moment can be beautiful because of how it's done (technique), why it matters (context), or what it reveals (human excellence)
 - Beauty in soccer is often dynamic — something unfolding in time, not a static object
 - Individual beauty vs Collective Beauty
 - Appreciation depends on football literacy — a kind of aesthetic education

Is beauty in soccer objective (form, technique) or subjective (emotion, narrative)?

Is a beautiful moment still beautiful if it happens in a meaningless match?

Is beauty tied to success, or can failure be beautiful (a brilliant move that almost

works)?

Is beauty in soccer closer to art, craft, or nature?

2. Different national styles of football represent different *philosophies* of the game — what it is for, what counts as excellent play. Brazil's historical *jogo bonito* prioritized creativity and flair; Germany's tradition has emphasized collective organization and efficiency; Spain's tiki-taka prized possession and spatial intelligence.

Are these simply tactical preferences, or are they genuine **aesthetic** and perhaps even **ethical** positions about what football should be? Is the debate between them a philosophical debate?

- What the game is for: joy, mastery, control, efficiency, improvisation
- Style shapes what counts as excellence
- Jogo bonito treats beauty as spontaneity, risk, and expressive movement.
- German football treats beauty as order, harmony, and collective precision.
- Tiki - taka treats beauty as pattern, patience, and spatial geometry.
- **Push further:** What would it mean for one footballing philosophy to be **wrong** — not just different?
- Essence or is purely pluralistic
- Suppresses creativity
- Does winning determine which is right?

3. The World Cup goal — a Roberto Carlos free kick, Bergkamp's turn and finish against Argentina, Messi's dribble in 2018 — has an extraordinary cultural weight. A single goal can define a career, a nation's relationship to the sport, a generation's memory. Is a great goal an *aesthetic object* in the philosophical sense?

- How does it compare to a great poem or piece of music?
- intrinsic vs extrinsic
- contemplation vs consumption
- repeatable vs unrepeatable
- individual vs collective

- Symbolic (Countries domination)
- mythologized (Translated into a narrative)

Conclusion

Discussion Questions

1. We have been looking at three frameworks, the ontology of sport, its epistemology, and its aesthetics. Do these three frameworks ultimately point toward the same unified thing or not? How do they relate to each other?
 - Essences with unified whole vs disparate and separate phenomena
 - Does Ontology of sport determine its aesthetic? (Rules, goals, and constraints)
 - Does Ontology of sport determine its epistemology? (Team sport vs individual sport)
 - What about Aesthetic and Epistemology? (Perfect play display of knowledge)
2. **Return to where we began.** At the start we asked: *why does sport matter?* — not why it is popular, not why it is profitable, but why a person who cares about what is true and beautiful and worth doing should take it seriously as a philosophical subject.

Ontology → Sport is a constructed world where meaning is voluntarily created.

Epistemology → Sport involves unique forms of knowing: tacit, embodied, perceptual.

Aesthetics → Sport generates beauty through movement, tension, and form.

- Sport exposes human limits — physical, psychological, moral
- It reveals truths about chance, contingency, and fate
- It shows how meaning can be constructed through rules, commitment, and shared imagination
- It is a laboratory for understanding competition, cooperation, and excellence
- Sport produces ephemeral beauty — movement, timing, harmony, improvisation.
- It creates beauty through constraint, like poetry or dance.

- It offers a form of beauty that is unscripted, emerging from real risk and uncertainty.
- The World Cup amplifies beauty by adding mythic stakes.
- Sport cultivates virtues: discipline, courage, resilience, teamwork.
- It creates shared emotion and collective identity without violence.
- It offers a rare space where effort, excellence, and fairness matter.
- It gives people a way to experience joy, flow, and embodied meaning.